political master Mikhail Gorbachev challenged his rigid loyalty to old-style socialism.

Then, as tumultuous changes swept through the Soviet bloc, everything in and around him collapsed in 1989. His health, his certainties, his ideology, his apparatus of power and his beloved SED party.

Terminally ill, he was brought to court to answer for his crimes.

In the last resort, detractors called Honecker a political opportunist long out of touch with his own people, while supporters described a man of conviction who – during his imprisonment and eventual exile – remained devoted to the communist cause.

Even as his world collapsed, Honecker retained a sense of humour and is said to have laughed out loud at a popular joke that lampooned his legacy. It told how he returned to East Berlin late one evening from an official visit abroad. Although the whole city was brightly lit, the streets were deserted. Eventually, Honecker's car passed the Berlin Wall, where he let himself be driven along only to discover a huge gaping hole and a painted sign saying: 'Erich, as you're the last one to leave, please turn off the lights.'

Although haunted by the fall of the Berlin Wall, Honecker died in 1994 still believing the GDR was the envy of the world: no unemployment, no drugs, no capitalistic exploitation and virtually no crime. But as will become clear, the reality was quite different.